

Committee of the Whole Meeting

1.24.2022 - 5:30PM

5:33PM Roll Call: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatez, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn

The Purpose of the Meeting is to discuss proposed changes to Subcommittee Structure and Function as detailed in the Policy BDE as outlined below.

1. Be it resolved that the Medford School Committee will amend policy BDE - Subcommittees of the School Committee:

The School Committee maintains a set of standing subcommittees during each term. It may establish special subcommittees for a specific purpose and to make recommendations for Committee action per policy [BDF](#).

1. The Committee chairperson, subject to approval by the Committee, will establish standing committees in the first month of each term. The subcommittee will be established through action of the Committee.
2. The Committee chairperson, subject to approval by the Committee, will appoint the subcommittee chairperson and its members.
3. The subcommittee may only meet to carry out business referred to it by a majority vote of the Committee. Subcommittees will not meet to conduct business brought to the Subcommittee by any other means or process. Subcommittees will be provided with a list of its functions and duties.
4. The subcommittee may make recommendations for Committee action, but it may not act for the School Committee.
5. The Committee chairperson and Superintendent will be ex-officio members of all special subcommittees.
6. A subcommittee will be dissolved by the Committee upon completion of its assignment, or it may be dissolved by a vote of the Committee at any time.

CROSS REF.: [BEC](#), Executive Sessions

- *Offered by Jenny Graham*

Jenny Graham: First change was to strike the names of the subcommittees from the policy so they could be determined each year. Another is purpose of meeting: when business has been passed to them by the committee. Other than that, changes are minor such as chairperson from chairman

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Meeting is not on public access yet. Live on Youtube and on zoom but working on getting the Medford TV link.

Melanie McLaughlin: In number three, can we clarify who will provide the list of functions for the subcommittees? Statement from SEPAC Co-chairs that they would like me to read:

Special education parent advisory council (SEPAC) statement. We represent and advocate for Medford's students with disabilities and their families.

The SEPAC has concerns about the language that is proposed regarding school subcommittee meetings, specifically on how it affects the activity of the special education subcommittee.

SEPAC has advised and advocated with the school committee for many years. A forum needed to be created for a closer collaboration between school committee and SEPAC, a collaboration which is not optional, but mandated by law. Per *Massachusetts Statute, Chapter 71B: Section 3: - The parent advisory council duties shall include but are not limited to: advising the school committee on matters that pertain to the education and safety of students with a disability; meeting regularly with school officials to participate in the planning and development of the school committee's special education programs.*

As a result of SEPAC advocacy, the special education subcommittee was created in 2018 to fulfill this requirement of SEPAC advising and collaborating with the school committee. Back then we had a different mayor, a different superintendent, and a different school committee.

The special education subcommittee works differently than other subcommittees because it has a different role - that of collaboration between school committee, SEPAC, and the special education department. Part of the assignment of the special education subcommittee is a dialog with SEPAC. An agenda set entirely by the school committee is no longer a dialog. We are concerned regarding the proposed language that *"The subcommittee may only meet to carry out business referred to it by a majority vote of the Committee. Subcommittees will not meet to conduct business brought to the Subcommittee by any other means or process "*. By the advising nature of SEPAC, our mandated role is to bring business to the attention of the school committee. We are concerned of a circular situation in which the subcommittee cannot meet because there is no agenda, and we have no agenda because we cannot meet.

In addition, we are concerned by the proposed language that *"A subcommittee will be dissolved by the Committee upon completion of its assignment, or it may be dissolved by a vote of the Committee at any time."* The language suggests that a subcommittee can be dissolved for any reason, even if the subcommittee's assignment might be ongoing and still relevant.

So many of you were not part of the history of the special education subcommittee. SEPAC is asking the members of the school committee to reemphasize and renew the commitment of collaborating with SEPAC, for the benefit of the students and families we are representing. We hope everyone here agrees with us on the amount of progress that has been made in the district regarding disability related policies since we started this closer collaboration. The impact of this collaboration was recognized and commanded by DESE in their most recent special education review.

We are asking that you maintain the role of the special education subcommittee, which is that of continuous dialog and collaboration between SEPAC and the school committee, not only to fulfill the requirements of the law, but also Medford's recent commitment for family engagement and family-school partnership.

Thank you.

Tonya Sullivan, co-chair

Alex Lauric, co-chair

Amendment: By whom will functions and duties be provided?

Mea Mustone: Mayor would provide a list of priorities and then we would decide which we want to be on.

Melanie McLaughlin: Not the names, it's the functions and duties I am looking for.

Kathy Kreatz: I have the same question. Paul Ruseau is drafting a list of policies in the next meeting. I am wondering for now, can we remove that and put it back in later?

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Remove the last sentence of number 3: Subcommittees will be provided with a list of its functions and duties.

Melanie McLaughlin: reading a message from SEPAC: get from Melanie:

Paul Ruseau: Our job as SC members is to write policy not just talk about it. Write, edit, delete, change policy. It is important that we clarify the point in the letter is not accurate.

Kathy Kreatz: The way that I read it, some of the items fit every subcommittee. The Building and Grounds committee does not set policy. We talk about updates to buildings and grounds. We were not making policy. The same can be said for the Personnel subcommittee. It is not all about policy.

Melanie McLaughlin: Part of the discussion; what is policy? Policy is participatory. We get feedback from our community on how we set policy. SEPAC asked for a subcommittee on Special Education for many years. Disability awareness curriculum was set because of the Special Education subcommittee and SEPAC. SEPAC doesn't have purview over curriculum. It is back to family, community engagement not just passing policy as seven members.

Paul Ruseau: The policy should be black and white and printed in our manual. The superintendent needs to know what we set as our policy. We should not be passing a policy that intends to be violated in certain circumstances. I don't disagree that practice is organic but policy cannot be organic. The out of school suspension policy includes except when law enforcement requires it.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: If we change this policy, will it deter the SE sub from discussing great ideas like Best Buddies?

Paul Ruseau: A member can propose a motion to bring it to the subcommittee. As far as the sign, the subcommittee came up with the idea and did all the work before it got approved by the full committee. Our staff need to attend these meetings before it is even approved by the SC.

Melanie McLaughlin: The process of setting policy is organic. Not policy is organic. It requires community and staff engagement. We roundtable these things to see if a policy needs to be set. When we talk about things being black and white, that is subjective. It is open to interpretation. I believe the community needs to be involved in driving policy. I don't understand. The Best Buddies would only come to SC if it had a cost associated with it. How do we know that until we talk with the constituents? We have subcommittee notes that we approve. I don't feel it should be dictated by black and white. Relationship building is not black and white.

Kathy Kreatz : I understand what you want us to do. I am the B/G chair. As far as the sign goes; I got comments from the community that we needed a sign. Would I need to make a motion to have a meeting to discuss the sign? Some of these subcommittees are not always making policy. I have been thinking about how there can be exceptions to the rule. In some subcommittees, we could have regularly scheduled meetings per year. The rule is so specific for the policy making subcommittees but it doesn't work for all of them. Ms. Van der Kloot told me that this was how the old subcommittee policy was.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: I believe it can work with the terms "carry out business". That helps a little bit. It starts as a resolution.

Jenny Graham: The benefit of doing it this way, we are going to talk tonight about the crossroads with the Medford High School building. Without a plan, we need to determine what to spend right now to make the students experience better right now. If this came to the committee first, it would have come to the full committee first and get approved before it creates another meeting and search for bids. I do think having the collaboration and discussion here is important. I always want to know what SEPAC has to say. I believe they deserve a time to speak before the committee. We do want to hear from SEPAC. We can always make a resolution to meet with SEPAC on a specific topic.

Melanie McLaughlin: I agree there needs to be structure with the subcommittees. I want to come back to the point: Sepac want to have an ongoing dialog with members of the School Committee so they can see the process of setting policy. Perhaps the SEPAC meeting needs to happen at the beginning of the year but that is not a conversation. We really need to think about how we are being inclusive in bringing in opinions of the community. Part of the problem was SC members don't attend the SEPAC meetings. I want to go on the record saying this is not inclusive and is not engaging families at all. DESE lauded our district on the relationship built with SEPAC. I am concerned that this will affect that relationship.

Kathy Kreatz; I would like to add it as an exception. When I think about Melanie Mclaughlin's committee, it will be difficult to follow the resolution protocol to go to subcommittee. If the meetings are informational, I think it is beneficial to continue the meetings as long as it is agreed upon how many meetings will be held each year. Why can't we have something specific with the BH subcommittee on how many times we will meet.

Melanie McLaughlin: Thank you member Kreatz. I appreciate the willingness to negotiate. Negotiation is an important part of the process. I do want to mention that in addition to the recommendation by DESE, we had members from other towns attend our meetings and ask for our help.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Is there an amendment to reach a middle ground to set a policy.

Kathy Kreatz: I would like to make an amendment that allows subcommittees to be able to schedule as needed to have up to one or two scheduled meetings for discussion per year. I don't know that all the committees will do that but it makes sense for some.

Melanie: Yes.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn : Have the opportunity to brainstorm ideas and then come back to the committee.

Melanie McLaughlin: I would love to know the opinion of the Director of Pupil Services. I would agree that a monthly meeting for every subcommittee is too much.

Mea Mustone: I value our relationship with SEPAC and the MPS is dedicated to meeting the needs of all of students. In terms of all the subcommittees in totality, last year's schedule was taxing. For some of the meetings, we had to call on the same representatives multiple times. It needs to be a balance between how much is too much and how much is enough? Not necessarily every month. Moving to nine subcommittees is concerning. Colleagues in other districts have three or four subcommittees that meet every so often.

Melanie McLaughlin: I didn't understand the difference between Pupil Services and Special Education and Behavioral Health. Last year there were too many meetings and the meetings were way too long. I do want to discuss the Subcommittee names and assignments.

Supt. Edouard-Vincent: I wasn't involved in the creation of the 9 subcommittees.

Melanie McLaughlin: We can't have these conversations outside of this setting because of open meeting law.

Jenny Graham: To member Kreatz's point, add to Number 3: Subcommittees may meet in the beginning of the school year to have one listening session at the beginning of the year. with the members of the community.

Paul Ruseau: Second it.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Strike sentence from number 3 and add a listening session.

Kathy Kreatz: I would like to add another potential meeting if necessary.

Jenny Graham: I am not willing to change the amendment.

ROLL: Jenny Graham: yes, Sharon Hays: yes; Kathy Kreatz: yes, Melanie McLaughlin: no; Mea Mustone: yes, Paul Ruseau: yes; Mayor Lungo-Koehn; yes
6/1 new policy passes:

Approved: Motioned to strike partial last sentence in number 3 of policy.

Approved: Each subcommittee may convene one meeting at the beginning of each year to conduct a listening session with the community.

Melanie McLaughlin: What about the assignments?

Jenny Graham: It does say addressing structure and function so I think it is reasonable to discuss Structure and assignment.

Melanie McLaughlin: I don't understand the difference between Pupil Services and BH/SPEC.

Jenny Graham: I am under the belief that SE/BH meet separately. I would suggest we remove Special Education from that title BH/Special Ed.

Melanie McLaughlin: Can we define what pupil services are? It is not advisable to strike Special education from the subcommittee name.

Jenny: Can we remove pupil services?

Melanie McLaughlin: Motion to remove Pupil services as a sub?

All in favor: Aye; Pupil Services is struck from the subcommittee list.

Motion to adjourn: 6:29 PM: 7/0